

Laston Petro Manja

Economics Ph.D. Candidate, University of Michigan

Lecturer in Economics, University of Malawi

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 Google Scholar |  ORCID |  LinkedIn |  GitHub

EDUCATION

- 2023 – Ph.D. in Economics, University of Michigan, Ann Arbor, MI.
Research fields: Development Economics, Labor Economics
- 2016 – 2018 M.A. in Economics, University of Malawi, Zomba, Malawi
- 2011 – 2015 Bachelor of Social Science (Economics), University of Malawi, Zomba, Malawi

RELEVANT WORK EXPERIENCE

- 2020 – Lecturer in Economics, Department of Economics, University of Malawi
- 2021 – 2023 Research Assistant, University of Michigan
- 2019 – 2020 Education Analyst Consultant, The World Bank
- 2019 – 2020 Finance, Competitiveness, and Innovation Consultant, The World Bank
- 2018 – 2020 Macroeconomics, Trade, and Investment Consultant, The World Bank
- 2018 – 2019 Research and Teaching Assistant, University of Malawi
- 2016 – 2018 Part-time Lecturer, University of Malawi

TEACHING

University of Michigan

- Winter 2026 Principles of Macroeconomics (ECON 102), Head Graduate Student Instructor (GSI)
- Fall 2025 Principles of Macroeconomics (ECON 102), Graduate Student Instructor (GSI)
- Winter 2025 Principles of Microeconomics (ECON 101), Graduate Student Instructor (GSI)
- Fall 2024 Principles of Macroeconomics (ECON 102), Graduate Student Instructor (GSI)

University of Malawi (Undergraduate and Masters Lecturer)

- 2021 – 2023 Advanced Macroeconomics (ECO 620)
- 2020 – 2022 Monetary Economics (ECO 322)
- 2021 – 2022 Labor Economics (ECO 413)
- 2021 – 2022 The Malawi Economy (ECO 224)
- 2022 Development Economics (DEC 313)
- 2022 Monitoring and Evaluation (DEC 423)
- 2021 History of Economic Thought (ECO 214)

RESEARCH FIELDS

Development Economics; Labor Economics; Education; Public Finance; Political Economy; African Economic Development

SELECTED RESEARCH IN PROGRESS

1. Colonizer Identity and Economic Development: Evidence from the “Scramble for Africa”, with Thomas Lloyd.
2. School Finance, Administrative Capacity, and Resilience in Malawi. Third-year paper.

SELECTED PEER-REVIEWED PRE-PH.D. JOURNAL ARTICLES

1. Manja, L. P., Zingwe, D. E., & Kamangila, A. E. (2025). **Smallholder farming commercialization and food security in Malawi: Do land rights and intrahousehold bargaining power matter?** *Agriculture & Food Security*, 14, 2.

2. Tembo, D., Manja, L. P., & Joshua, M. K. (2025). **Faith and food in rural Malawi: An investigation into the sociocultural determinants of household food security.** *Food, Culture & Society*, 28(4), 1055–1083.
3. Manja, L. P., & Badjie, I. A. (2025). **Does household welfare change with finance access? The case of women and the youth in The Gambia.** *Review of Development Economics*, 29(1), 64–104.
4. Chirwa, G. C., Manja, L. P., Chasukwa, M., Gunde, A., Dulani, B., Kayuni, H., & Chinsinga, B. (2023). **Assessing the relationship between digital divide and citizens' political participation in Africa.** *Development Southern Africa*, 40(6), 1258–1276.
5. Zingwe, D. E., Banda, A. E., & Manja, L. P. (2023). **The effects of remittances on household food nutrition security in the context of multiple shocks in Malawi.** *Cogent Food & Agriculture*, 9(1).
6. Salima, W., Manja, L. P., Chiwaula, L. S., & Chirwa, G. C. (2023). **The impact of credit access on household food security in Malawi.** *Journal of Agriculture and Food Research*, 11, 100490.
7. Manja, L. P., & Badjie, I. A. (2022). **The welfare effects of formal and informal financial access in The Gambia: A comparative assessment.** *SAGE Open*, 12(1).
8. Manja, L. P., Silumbu, E. B. D., & Chaweza, R. D. C. (2022). **Determinants of demand for international reserves in the SADC region.** *African Review of Economics and Finance*, 1–28.
9. Kambewa, P., Khangamwa, L., Masanjala, W., Chaweza, R., & Manja, L. P. (2022). The impact of ill-health on welfare of rural agricultural households of Teuka Village in Zomba District, Malawi: An application of the individual household modelling approach. *Malawi Journal of Economics*, 3(1), 1–13.
10. Zingwe, D. E., Manja, L. P., & Chirwa, E. W. (2021). **The effects of engendered intra-household power dynamics on household food security and nutrition in Malawi.** *Journal of Gender Studies*.
11. Al-Hanawi, M. K., Chirwa, G. C., Kamninga, T. M., & Manja, L. P. (2020). **Effects of financial inclusion on access to emergency funds for healthcare in the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia.** *Journal of Multidisciplinary Healthcare*, 13, 1157–1167.

PRE-PH.D. WORKING PAPERS

1. Manja, L. P. (2022). **Payment Delays for Cash Transfers: The Role of Subsistence Constraints.** University of Michigan African Presidential Scholars Fellowship Working Paper.
2. Manja, L. P., & Badjie, I. A. (2022). **The Impacts of Access to Finance on Household Welfare: A Mixed Methods Approach for Women and the Youth in The Gambia.** African Economic Research Consortium Working Paper.

SELECTED CO-AUTHORED REPORTS

1. World Bank. (2019). **Malawi Economic Monitor, December 2019: Strengthening Human Capital Through Nutrition.** Lilongwe, Malawi: World Bank.
2. World Bank. (2019). **Malawi Economic Monitor, June 2019: Charting a New Course.** Lilongwe, Malawi: World Bank.
3. World Bank. (2018). **Malawi Economic Monitor, November 2018: Investing in Girls' Education.** Washington, DC: World Bank.

BOOK CHAPTER

1. Mwale, M. L., Chirwa, G. C., Kamninga, T. M., & Manja, L. P. (2021). **Trust in Election Management Bodies, Participation in Demonstrations and Willingness to Pay Taxes: Evidence from Malawi.** In K. Ross, A. L. Chiweza, & W. O. Mulwafu (Eds.), *Beyond Impunity: New Directions for Governance in Malawi* (pp. 97–114).

RESEARCH GRANTS

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| 2026 | Rackham Graduate Student Research Grant, University of Michigan |
| 2026 | Co-Grantee, U-M ISR Marshall Weinberg Fellowship in Population, Development and Climate Change |
| 2026 | Co-Grantee, U-M African Studies Center Support for Student Research and Internships in Africa |
| 2021 | Co-Grantee, AERC "Inclusive Finance for Fragile and Post-Conflict States in Africa" Project |
| 2019 | Co-Grantee, IFPRI "Enhancing the Impact of Agricultural Extension in Malawi" Project |
| 2019 | Co-Grantee, AERC AFPON Project |

FELLOWSHIPS, AWARDS, AND SCHOLARSHIPS

- 2022 University of Michigan African Presidential Scholars Program
- 2018 World Bank Internship, awarded to top graduate student from the University of Malawi
- 2016 AERC-CMAP Joint Facility for Electives Scholarship, Kenyan School of Monetary Studies
- 2011 – 2015 University of Malawi Dean’s List Awards; Government of Malawi National Merit Scholarship

SEMINAR AND CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS

- 2026 Midwest International Economic Development Conference (MWIEDC), Madison, WI.
- 2026 Michigan Development Economics Conference (MDev), Ann Arbor, MI.
- 2023 AERC-IDRC Dissemination Workshop on “Inclusive Finance for Fragile and Post-Conflict Contexts in Africa,” Banjul, The Gambia.
- 2020 Manja, L. P., & Silumbu, E. B. D. **The Comparative Potential Growth-Enhancing Effects of the AfCFTA and COMESA Trade Regimes.** Seventh COMESA Annual Research Forum, Virtual, October 19–21. Published in *COMESA Key Issues in Regional Integration*, Vol. 9.
- 2019 AERC Workshop on “Agricultural and Food Policy Analysis for Nutrition Outcomes,” Nairobi, Kenya.

SERVICE

- 2026 – Co-President, African Graduate Student Association (AGSA), University of Michigan
- 2025 – 2026 Treasurer, African Graduate Student Association (AGSA), University of Michigan
- 2025 – 2026 Co-organizer of the Development Workshop (DevWorkshop) seminar in the Department of Economics, University of Michigan
- 2020 – Student mentorship at the University of Malawi
- 2017 Co-started Chirimba Youth Organization to address drug and substance abuse and support school dropouts’ return to school
- 2015 Electoral Commissioner for University of Malawi student leader elections

SKILLS, LANGUAGES, AND CITIZENSHIP

- Statistical: Stata, R, Julia, Python, EViews, NVivo, CPro, SPSS
- Administrative: L^AT_EX, JabRef, Git, Microsoft Office Suite, project management, project administration
- Survey Design: SurveyCTO, ODK, World Bank CAPI/CAWI
- Research: Proposal writing, data collection, data analysis, report writing, monitoring and evaluation
- Languages: English (fluent); Chichewa (native)
- Citizenship: Malawian.